12
Rio's ruinous mega-events

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In the last decade, all the BRICS countries have invested enormous financial resources and political prestige in hosting mega-sports events: the 2008 Summer Olympics in Beijing, the 2010 Commonwealth Games in Delhi, the 2010 FIFA World Cup in South Africa, the 2014 Winter Olympics and the upcoming 2018 FIFA World Cup in Russia – the latter replicating Brazil's 'double' approach of FIFA World Cup (2014) and Olympic Games (Rio de Janeiro 2016). It is also nearly certain that South Africa (Durban) will host the Commonwealth Games in 2022 and will bid for the 2024 Olympics, and that Beijing will bid for a Winter Olympics.

In other words, there is a trend whereby mega-sports events and so-called 'emerging economies' grow closer. These countries combine three crucial elements: availability of resources; an ambition to strengthen their image as an emerging power worldwide; and relative weakness of institutions which protect the environment and human rights. The combination of these elements enables host cities to abide by the 'package' of interventions that international organising committees such as the Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) and the International Olympic Committee (IOC) require.

This chapter will start with describing the 'global city' – the importance for cities today in making themselves present on the global stage to compete for investments. Then it will show how mega-sports events have become a central strategy for cities in the South branding themselves as 'global cities'. The inherent characteristics of hosting such events, which demands flexible planning to respond to the demands of private investors, challenges existing institutional